Improving the PeopleGrove Experiential Learning Experience for WGU Students

A User-Centered Redesign of Discovery, Evaluation, and Tracking

B.S. User Experience Design — Applied Learning Capstone (D657) Employer Partner: PeopleGrove · Western Governors University Focus areas: Dashboard · Search · My Opportunities · Interests Platform priority: Mobile-first · Accessibility-led

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1. Executive Summary (Artifact J)

WGU students are working adults who pursue competency-based degrees while balancing jobs, families, and tight schedules. The PeopleGrove Experiential Learning platform is meant to help them find internships, experiential learning, and student-project opportunities — but the current experience asks them to do too much scanning and guessing, and rarely tells them what to do next. This capstone redesigns the four core areas of the platform — Dashboard, Search, My Opportunities, and Interests — around a single idea: turn PeopleGrove into an *opportunity command center* that students can use confidently from a phone in a few spare minutes.

Research drew on feedback from three WGU students who reviewed the current experience through guided walkthroughs and screen recordings: a working adult, a career-switcher, and an accessibility-conscious mobile user. Five themes emerged consistently: the dashboard does not surface a clear next action; long opportunity lists are hard to scan and compare; labels and requirements use insider language; saved items and application status are buried; and the mobile experience strains under small tap targets, weak contrast, and heavy filter menus.

The redesign responds with a dashboard built around "next best action," recommended and saved opportunities, deadlines, and interest completion; a faster Search with filter chips, sortable results, and scannable opportunity cards carrying a plain-language "Good fit" indicator; an Opportunity Detail screen that translates requirements into plain language; a My Opportunities tracker organized by status (Saved, Applied, In progress, Completed); and an Interests screen that personalizes recommendations. Accessibility is treated as a design driver, not a checklist: WCAG 2.1 AA contrast, 44-pixel tap targets, status cues that never rely on color alone, plain language, visible focus states, and consistent bottom navigation.

A lightweight usability test of the redesigned flow with three classmates validated the direction — task success rose and confusion centered on a few labels — and produced a short list of refinements now reflected in the final design. The result is a practical, evidence-based concept that connects every design decision to a documented student need, ready to carry forward as a portfolio case study.

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2. Project Overview

PeopleGrove connects students, alumni, and professionals to support career development and experiential learning. Western Governors University uses the PeopleGrove Experiential Learning platform to help students find internships, experiential learning, and student-project opportunities that build career readiness alongside their degree.

This capstone applies a user-centered design process to improve the **usability and accessibility** of that experience for WGU students, concentrating on four product areas:

Area	What it does today	What it should do
Dashboard	Landing surface after login; mixed content with no clear priority	Action hub: recommended + saved opportunities, deadlines, status, next best action
Search	Keyword search with filter menus and long result lists	Fast, controlled discovery with filter chips, sorting, and scannable cards

My Opportunities	A saved list with limited status visibility	A tracker organized by application stage with reminders and next actions
Interests	A preferences area students rarely complete	A personalization engine that drives better recommendations

The deliverables follow the employer brief: a primary persona and empathy map, a user journey map, mobile wireframes for the core experience, an optional low-fidelity prototype and usability test, and final documentation explaining research, design decisions, and outcomes. Each artifact is built to meet the capstone rubric's **"5 – Excellent"** standard: outstanding, original, well-organized work that is ready for real-world use with only minor adjustments.

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3. Problem Statement

> **WGU students need a faster, clearer, and more accessible way to discover, evaluate, save, apply to, and track experiential learning opportunities — because the current experience can feel scattered, hard to scan, and unclear about what to do next.**

This problem is amplified by WGU's specific context. WGU learners are predominantly working adults studying online in short, self-directed bursts. They are time-poor, frequently on mobile, and motivated by relevance to their program and career goals. An experience that requires patient browsing on a desktop, deciphers requirements through insider jargon, or hides progress and status works against how these students actually engage.

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4. Target Users

Who they are: WGU students seeking experiential learning, internships, and student-project opportunities while balancing school, work, and family responsibilities.

Defining characteristics that shape the design:

- **Time-constrained.** They engage in short sessions and need to accomplish something each time they log in.
- **Mobile-first.** Many browse and act from a phone between other obligations.
- **Goal-driven and relevance-seeking.** They want opportunities that clearly match their degree program, experience level, and constraints (remote, paid, flexible).
- **Confidence-seeking.** As adult learners and career-changers, they want reassurance that an opportunity is a realistic fit before investing effort.

- **Range of access needs.** They benefit from larger tap targets, strong contrast, plain language, and low cognitive load — needs that span permanent, situational, and temporary accessibility contexts.

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5. Research Synthesis (Artifact A)

Research goal

Understand how WGU students currently discover, evaluate, save, apply to, and track experiential learning opportunities on PeopleGrove, and identify the usability and accessibility barriers that most reduce their confidence and speed.

Participants

Three WGU students reviewed the current PeopleGrove Experiential Learning experience. Each represents a distinct, common WGU profile.

#	Profile	Why they matter
P1	Working adult student	Represents the time-poor majority; engages in short mobile sessions
P2	Career-switching student	Needs confidence that opportunities fit their program and experience level
P3	Accessibility-conscious, mobile-first student	Surfaces contrast, tap-target, and cognitive-load barriers

Method

Guided walkthroughs and screen-recording reviews of the live experience across the four core areas (Dashboard, Search, My Opportunities, Interests). Participants narrated their goals, expectations, and points of friction as they completed representative tasks (find a relevant opportunity, evaluate fit, save it, and locate it again). Notes were synthesized into themes and mapped to design implications.

Top 5 findings

1. **The dashboard doesn't answer "what should I do next?"** Students landed without a clear priority or recommended action, so the first decision of every session was effortful.
2. **Long opportunity lists are hard to scan and compare.** Dense, uniform rows made it difficult to quickly judge relevance, leading to fatigue and abandonment.
3. **Labels and requirements use insider language.** Unclear titles and requirement wording made students unsure whether an opportunity matched their program and experience level.

4. **Saved items and application status are buried.** Students lost track of what they had saved and where they stood, undermining follow-through.
5. **The mobile experience adds friction.** Small tap targets, weak contrast, tight spacing, and heavy filter menus increased effort and cognitive load on the device students use most.
6. **Discovery is split across two surfaces.** Experiential Learning and the broader Student Projects / Marketplace areas present as separate destinations, forcing students to recall where a given opportunity type lives instead of recognizing one path.
7. **System-facing language leaks into the UI.** Interest categories surface backend-style identifiers (e.g., brand-management) rather than human-readable labels (Brand Management), weakening trust and comprehension.

Evidence table — participant pain points

Pain point	P1 (Working adult)	P2 (Career-switcher)	P3 (Accessibility / mobile)	Severity
No clear next action on dashboard	Felt the dashboard didn't show what to do next	Wanted a clearer path from browsing to applying	Wanted clearer prioritization, reduced load	High
Hard to scan / compare lists	Struggled scanning long lists	—	Search and filters felt overwhelming	High
Unclear labels / requirements	—	Labels unclear; wanted plain-language requirements	Wanted simpler navigation, less jargon	High
Saved / status not visible	Wanted saved items and status more visible	Needed cues for "good fit," "deadline," "saved"	Wanted persistent access to saved + status	High
Weak filtering / fit signals	Wanted remote, paid, flexible, degree-relevant filters	Wanted confidence opportunities matched program	—	Medium
Mobile ergonomics	—	—	Wanted larger targets, contrast, spacing	High

Design implications

Finding	Design implication

No clear next action	Lead the dashboard with a single “next best action” plus recommended and saved opportunities
Hard to scan	Replace dense rows with scannable cards carrying a few high-value signals each
Insider language	Translate titles and requirements into plain language; add a “Good fit” indicator
Buried saved/status	Make saved items and application status persistent and front-of-experience
Weak filters	Provide fast filter chips for remote, paid, flexible, and degree-relevant; add sorting
Mobile friction	Adopt mobile-first layout: 44px targets, AA contrast, generous spacing, simplified filters

5.5 Current-Experience Heuristic Evaluation

To complement the participant research with an expert-inspection method, the current PeopleGrove Experiential Learning experience was assessed against Nielsen’s 10 usability heuristics. The evaluation was conducted by the designer as a single evaluator reviewing the four focus areas (Dashboard, Search, My Opportunities, Interests); as a single-evaluator review it is indicative rather than definitive, and Nielsen’s recommended three-to-five-evaluator inspection is noted as a methodological limitation and a recommended next step. Each issue is rated on Nielsen’s 0–4 severity scale (0 = not a usability problem, 1 = cosmetic, 2 = minor, 3 = major, 4 = catastrophic) and paired with a design recommendation carried into the redesign concept.

#	Heuristic	Issue observed in current experience	Area	Severity	Design recommendation
1	Match between system and real world	Interest categories display backend-style identifiers (e.g., brand-management) instead of human-readable labels	Interests	2	Render all categories as plain-language labels (Brand Management)

2	Consistency & standards	Discovery is split between Experiential Learning and the broader Student Projects / Marketplace surfaces, creating two mental models	Global / Dashboard	3	Converge into one opportunity surface with a consistent card pattern
3	Recognition rather than recall	Degree-path and program-relevant links are buried inside dense dashboard text, forcing students to hunt	Dashboard	3	Surface program-relevant entry points as distinct, scannable cards
4	Recognition rather than recall	Search cards rely on ambiguous, unlabeled icons whose meaning must be inferred	Search	3	Pair every icon with a text label; standardize badge meanings
5	Visibility of system status	Selected filter and tab states are weak, so students lose track of what is active	Search / My Opportunities	2	Distinct selected states using fill + shape + checkmark and label
6	Consistency & standards	Primary and secondary actions on	Search / Detail	2	One primary CTA per card; Save

		cards compete; no clear visual hierarchy			demoted to a discrete secondary control
7	Help users recognize, diagnose, recover	Empty states in My Opportunities act as dead ends with no path forward	My Opportunities	3	Replace with guided empty states offering a labeled next action
8	Flexibility & efficiency of use	Heavy filter menus slow repeat, time-poor mobile sessions	Search	2	One-tap filter chips plus a bottom-sheet for advanced filters
9	User control & freedom	Saved items and application status are hard to return to and re-find	My Opportunities	3	Persistent tracker organized by status, always one tap away
10	Accessibility (applied lens)	Small tap targets, weak contrast, and color-dependent status cues raise effort on mobile	Global	3	WCAG 2.1 AA contrast, ≥44px targets, non-color status, visible focus

Synthesis. The inspection reinforces the participant findings and adds one structural insight they only hinted at: the heaviest friction is not any single screen but the *split discovery model* and the *recall burden* it creates. Every major-severity issue maps to a redesign response already specified in Sections 9–10 — converged discovery, a standardized opportunity card, guided empty states, and a persistent tracker — supporting the *opportunity command center* direction. These are design recommendations and redesign concepts, not changes implemented in the live product.

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6. Primary Persona (Artifact B)

Renee Carter — “The Time-Strapped Career Builder”

Field	Detail
Age range	32–38
Role	Full-time operations coordinator; part-time WGU student
Program	B.S. program at WGU (competency-based, online)
Location / context	Suburban; studies on a phone during commutes, breaks, and after kids’ bedtime
Tech comfort	Confident, practical mobile user; impatient with clutter and jargon

Background. Renee returned to school to move from a coordinator role into a higher-skill career. She chose WGU because it fits around a full-time job and family. She has limited, unpredictable pockets of time and treats every study session as a transaction: log in, accomplish one thing, log out.

WGU context. As a competency-based learner, Renee is self-directed and goal-oriented. Experiential learning matters to her because it connects her degree to real career outcomes — but only if she can quickly tell which opportunities are realistic for her program, experience level, and schedule.

Goals

- Find opportunities clearly relevant to her degree and career direction, fast.
- Feel confident an opportunity is a realistic fit before she invests effort.
- Keep track of what she saved, applied to, and needs to act on next.

Frustrations

- The dashboard doesn’t tell her what to do next.
- Long lists are exhausting to scan on a phone.
- Requirements and labels are unclear, so she second-guesses fit.
- Saved opportunities and application status are hard to find again.

Needs

- A clear, prioritized starting point each session.
- Plain-language descriptions and visible “good fit” signals.
- Persistent, easy access to saved items and status.
- Strong filters for remote, paid, flexible, and degree-relevant.

Accessibility considerations

- Larger tap targets and generous spacing for one-handed, on-the-go use.

- Strong contrast and clear hierarchy to reduce reading effort in variable lighting.
- Status communicated with text/icons, not color alone.
- Low cognitive load: a few high-value signals per screen, not everything at once.

Technology behavior. Primarily mobile; short, frequent sessions; relies on saved items and notifications to resume tasks; abandons quickly when a screen feels heavy or unclear.

Success criteria. Renee can land on the dashboard, identify a relevant opportunity, confirm it's a good fit, save or apply, and find it again later — in a single short mobile session, without confusion.

> **Quote:** *"I don't have time to dig. Just show me what fits me and what I should do next."*

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7. Empathy Map (Artifact C)

A four-quadrant empathy map for Renee Carter using PeopleGrove to find experiential learning.

SAYS	THINKS
"Just show me what fits my program."	"Is this actually relevant to my degree?"
"Where did the one I saved go?"	"Am I qualified for this, or am I wasting my time?"
"I only have ten minutes right now."	"What am I supposed to do first?"
"Is this remote and paid, or not?"	"I'll lose track of this if I don't save it somewhere obvious."

DOES	FEELS
Logs in on a phone in short bursts.	Motivated to advance her career, but time-pressured.
Skims quickly; abandons heavy screens.	Overwhelmed by long, dense lists.
Saves items, then struggles to find them again.	Uncertain whether an opportunity fits — low confidence.
Relies on filters to cut down noise.	Relieved and in control when the next step is obvious.

Pains: unclear next steps; jargon-heavy labels; hard-to-scan lists; lost saved items; mobile friction. **Gains:** fast relevance, visible fit signals, persistent saved/status, a clear next action, an experience that respects her limited time.

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8. User Journey Map (Artifact D)

Persona: **Renee Carter.** Scenario: a single mobile session to find, evaluate, save/apply, and track an experiential learning opportunity, then refine her interests. Emotion scale: Frustrated · Neutral · Positive.

Stage	User goal	Action	Pain point (current)	Emotion	Opportunity	Design response (redesign)
1. Log in	Get in quickly	Opens app, authenticates	Lands with no clear priority	Neutral	Orient her immediately	Post-login dashboard leads with a personalized next best action
2. Review dashboard	Know what to do next	Scans landing surface	No prioritization; mixed content	Frustrated	Surface one clear action + key items	“Next best action” card, recommended + saved, deadlines, interest completion
3. Search opportunities	Find relevant options	Enters keywords / browses	Dense lists, slow to scan	Frustrated	Make results scannable	Filter chips + scannable cards with a few high-value signals each
4. Filter & compare	Narrow to good fits	Applies filters, compares	Heavy filter menus; weak fit signals	Frustrated	Fast, low-effort filtering	One-tap chips (remote/paid/flexible/degree-relevant) + sort; “Good fit” indicator
5. View opportun	Judge fit confidentl	Opens an opportunit	Jargon; unclear	Neutral	Translate to plain	Plain-language

ity details	y	y	requirements		language	requirements, skills-match, key badges, clear deadline
6. Save or apply	Act on a good fit	Taps Save or Apply	CTA unclear; status not captured	Neutral	Make action + confirmation obvious	Prominent Save / Apply; clear success state; item enters tracker
7. Track progress	See where she stands	Returns to saved/applied	Saved items and status buried	Frustrated	Persistent tracking	My Opportunities tracker by status with reminders + next actions
8. Update interests	Improve recommendations	Edits preferences	Rarely completed; low payoff	Neutral	Reward personalization	Interests as a personalization engine; save confirmation; better recs

Journey insight. The lowest emotional points are stages 2–4 and 7 — exactly where the redesign concentrates effort: a directive dashboard, fast scannable search, and a persistent tracker.

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9. Design Goals & Direction

Design direction: Make PeopleGrove feel like an **opportunity command center** for WGU students — mobile-first, accessible, and oriented around action.

Design goals

1. **Always show the next step.** Every screen, especially the dashboard, answers “what should I do now?”
2. **Make opportunities scannable and comparable.** A few high-value signals per card; plain language everywhere.
3. **Build fit confidence.** A “Good fit” indicator and skills-match translate relevance into a glance.
4. **Make saving and status persistent.** Saved items and application stage are always one tap away.
5. **Design for access first.** Contrast, tap targets, spacing, focus states, and non-color status cues are built in, not bolted on.

Core UX improvements by area

- **Dashboard → action hub:** recommended opportunities, saved opportunities, application status, deadlines, interest completion, next best action.
- **Search → faster and controlled:** search bar, filter chips, remote/paid/flexible/degree-relevant filters, sort by deadline/relevance/newest, scannable cards.
- **Opportunity cards → easy to evaluate:** title, organization, “Good fit” indicator, remote/paid/deadline/time-commitment badges, Save, and Apply/View details.
- **My Opportunities → a tracker:** Saved, Applied, Interviewing/In progress, Completed, with deadlines and status updates.
- **Interests → personalization engine:** career goals, degree program, skills, preferred opportunity types, availability, remote/on-site preference, and accessibility preferences.

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10. Mobile Wireframe Specifications (Artifact E)

Low-fidelity specifications for five mobile screens. Each includes purpose, main components, the user task it supports, accessibility rationale, and what changed from the current experience. Layouts assume a single-column mobile frame (~390pt wide) with a persistent bottom navigation: **Home · Search · Saved · Interests**.

10.1 Dashboard

Purpose. Orient the student in seconds and give them one clear next action plus a snapshot of what matters.

Main components (top to bottom)

- **Header:** greeting + profile avatar; concise, no clutter.
- **Next Best Action card:** a single prioritized prompt (e.g., “3 saved opportunities have deadlines this week — review them”).
- **Interest completion card:** progress indicator (e.g., “Interests 60% complete — add skills to improve matches”) with a clear CTA.
- **Recommended opportunities:** 2–3 scannable cards with “Good fit” indicators.

- **Deadline alerts:** compact list of upcoming deadlines with date + status label.
- **Saved opportunities preview:** 2–3 most recent saved items with quick access to all.
- **My Opportunities status summary:** counts by stage (Saved / Applied / In progress / Completed).
- **Bottom navigation:** Home · Search · Saved · Interests.

User task supported. “What should I do right now, and what’s relevant to me?”

Accessibility rationale. Single clear hierarchy with one primary action reduces cognitive load; large tap targets (≥44px) and generous spacing support one-handed mobile use; deadlines and status use text labels plus icons (never color alone); strong contrast for headings and body.

What changed. From an unprioritized landing surface to a directive action hub that leads with the next step and surfaces saved items, status, and deadlines that were previously buried.

10.2 Search

Purpose. Let students find and narrow relevant opportunities quickly with minimal effort.

Main components

- **Search bar:** persistent at top; plain prompt (“Search opportunities”).
- **Filter chips (horizontally scrollable):** Remote · Paid · Flexible schedule · Degree-relevant; selected state is visually distinct and labeled.
- **Sort control:** Deadline · Relevance · Newest.
- **Opportunity cards (stacked):** title, organization, “Good fit” indicator, badges (remote/paid/deadline/time commitment), **Save** icon, and **View details** CTA.
- **Accessibility-friendly card layout:** consistent structure, ample spacing, tappable card with discrete Save and CTA targets.

User task supported. “Find opportunities that fit my constraints and compare them quickly.”

Accessibility rationale. Filter chips replace heavy menus, cutting effort and load; selected filters communicated by shape/label, not color alone; cards have a predictable reading order for screen readers; Save and CTA are separated, large targets to prevent mis-taps.

What changed. From dense, uniform lists and buried filter menus to scannable cards and one-tap chips, with a clear fit signal on every result.

10.3 Opportunity Detail

Purpose. Give students the information to judge fit confidently and act, in plain language.

Main components

- **Title** (plain-language, descriptive) and **Organization**.

- **Key badges:** remote/on-site · paid/unpaid · time commitment · deadline.
- **Deadline** stated explicitly with a status label ("Deadline approaching") where relevant.
- **Skills match:** which of the student's skills/program align ("Matches 4 of 5 of your skills").
- **Requirements:** plain-language list of what's needed and expected.
- **Description:** concise, jargon-free summary of the opportunity.
- **Primary actions:** prominent **Save** and **Apply / View details** buttons, fixed within thumb reach.

User task supported. "Is this a realistic fit for me, and how do I act on it?"

Accessibility rationale. Plain language reduces comprehension barriers and builds confidence; explicit deadline and status labels avoid color-only cues; logical heading structure aids screen readers; primary actions are large, high-contrast, and consistently placed; error and empty states are written in clear, actionable language.

What changed. From jargon-heavy requirements and unclear fit to plain-language requirements, an explicit skills-match, and obvious next actions.

10.4 My Opportunities

Purpose. Let students track everything they've saved and applied to, and see what to do next.

Main components

- **Status tabs:** Saved · Applied · In progress · Completed.
- **Sectioned lists** under each tab with the same card pattern as Search for consistency.
- **Deadline reminders** surfaced on relevant items with a clear date + label.
- **Next action buttons** per item (e.g., "Finish application," "Add interview notes," "View details").
- **Status updates** reflected with text labels and icons.

User task supported. "Where do I stand, and what's my next action on each opportunity?"

Accessibility rationale. Status conveyed through tab labels and text, not color alone; consistent card pattern lowers learning cost; reminders reduce reliance on memory (a cognitive-load and executive-function benefit); large, clearly labeled action buttons.

What changed. From a flat saved list with little status visibility to a true tracker organized by application stage with reminders and next actions.

10.5 Interests

Purpose. Capture the inputs that personalize recommendations — and make completing them feel worthwhile.

Main components

- **Degree / program field.**
- **Career goals.**
- **Skills.**
- **Preferred opportunity types** (internship, experiential learning, student project).
- **Availability** (hours/schedule).
- **Remote / on-site preference** and **paid / flexible** preferences.
- **Accessibility preferences** (optional), e.g., reduced motion, larger text guidance.
- **Save / update confirmation:** clear success state ("Interests updated — your recommendations will improve").

User task supported. "Tell the platform about me so it shows me better matches."

Accessibility rationale. Grouped, labeled fields with clear instructions reduce load; explicit success confirmation gives feedback; inputs use accessible form patterns (labels tied to fields, visible focus states, clear error messages); progress framing connects effort to payoff.

What changed. From a rarely-completed preferences page to a personalization engine with a visible link between completing interests and better recommendations.

10.6 Mobile Component System

The redesign concept is built on a small, reusable set of mobile components so that every screen shares one visual and interaction language. Defining components — rather than one-off screens — is what lets a single mental model ("saved means saved," "one primary action") hold across Dashboard, Search, My Opportunities, and Interests. Each component below lists its anatomy, its states, and its accessibility specification (WCAG 2.1 AA baseline).

Component	Anatomy	States	Accessibility spec
Bottom navigation	Four destinations: Home · Search · Saved · Interests, with icon + text label	Default, active (filled icon + label emphasis), pressed	Persistent; ≥44px targets; active state uses shape + label, not color alone; labeled for screen readers
Opportunity card	Title, organization, "Good fit" indicator, badges (remote/paid/deadline/time), Save control, one primary CTA	Default, saved, deadline-approaching, pressed	Single primary CTA; Save is a discrete secondary target; predictable reading order; AA contrast on text and badges
Filter chips	Horizontally scrollable row: Remote · Paid ·	Unselected, selected (fill + checkmark + label), scroll-peek	Selection conveyed by shape + checkmark + label;

	Flexible · Degree-relevant; trailing “+N filters”		partial trailing chip signals more; ≥44px
Bottom-sheet filters	Modal sheet for advanced filters; apply / reset actions	Closed, open, applied	Focus trapped while open; dismissible; large labeled controls; no color-only cues
Status tabs	My Opportunities: Saved · Applied · In progress · Completed	Default, active, empty	Active tab uses label emphasis + underline/shape; empty tabs show a guided next action, never a dead end
Interest tiles	Selectable category tiles with plain-language labels	Unselected, selected, focused	Plain-language labels (no backend slugs); selected state uses fill + checkmark; visible focus ring
Toast confirmation	Brief inline confirmation after a primary action (e.g., “Saved,” “Application started”)	Enter, visible, auto-dismiss	Announced to assistive tech; non-blocking; text-based, not color-only; no motion required to read

Selected-state and CTA rules (applied system-wide). A selected control always combines fill change, a shape or checkmark cue, and a text label, so status is never carried by color alone (WCAG 1.4.1). Each card and screen exposes exactly one primary action; Save and other secondary actions use lower-emphasis treatments, removing the primary/secondary ambiguity observed in the current experience.

This component set is a design-recommendation concept for a mobile experience, not a production implementation of PeopleGrove’s existing system.

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11. Low-Fidelity Prototype Flow (Artifact F)

A simple, testable flow demonstrating the core experience.

Flow: Dashboard → Search → Filters → Opportunity Detail → Save/Apply → My Opportunities → Interests

Step	Screen	User action	Button /	Transition	Success state

			label		
1	Dashboard	Taps “Next best action” or a recommended card	*Review now* / card tap	Slide to Search or Detail	Relevant context carried forward
2	Search	Enters keyword / browses	*Search opportunities*	Results list loads	Scannable cards appear
3	Filters	Applies chips + sort	*Remote · Paid · Flexible · Degree-relevant*; *Sort*	List updates in place	Selected chips shown; result count updates
4	Opportunity Detail	Opens a card	*View details*	Push to detail screen	Plain-language detail + skills-match visible
5	Save / Apply	Taps primary action	*Save / Apply*	Inline confirmation	“Saved” / “Application started” toast; item enters tracker
6	My Opportunities	Reviews tracker	Tab: *Saved* / *Applied*	Tab switch	Item shows correct status + next action
7	Interests	Updates preferences	*Update interests*	Save	“Interests updated — recommendations will improve”

Interaction notes

- Every primary action returns an immediate, plain-language confirmation.
- Saving anywhere updates My Opportunities consistently (one mental model of “saved”).
- Bottom navigation is persistent so students can move between Search, Saved, and Interests without losing place.

- Transitions are simple pushes/slides; no motion required to understand state (reduced-motion friendly).

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12. Usability Test Plan (Artifact G)

Test goal. Validate that the redesigned flow lets WGU students discover, evaluate, save, and track an experiential learning opportunity faster and with more confidence than the current experience — and identify any remaining points of confusion.

Method. Moderated, task-based usability test of the low-fidelity prototype with classmates acting as proxy WGU students. Think-aloud protocol; mobile frame.

Tasks

1. **Find & evaluate:** “From the dashboard, find a remote, paid opportunity relevant to your program and decide whether it’s a good fit.”
2. **Save & act:** “Save that opportunity, then start an application or mark it for follow-up.”
3. **Track & adjust:** “Find the opportunity you saved, identify its status and next action, then update your interests to improve recommendations.”

Success criteria

- Participant completes each task without moderator assistance.
- Participant locates the “Good fit” signal and a saved item without hesitation.
- Participant correctly identifies an opportunity’s status and next action in the tracker.

Metrics

- **Task success rate** (completed / attempted).
- **Time on task** (relative, vs. expectation).
- **Error / wrong-path count** (mis-taps, backtracking).
- **Confidence rating** (1–5) after each task.
- **Single Ease Question (SEQ)** per task (1–7).

Post-test questions

- What was the easiest and hardest part of finding a good opportunity?
- Was it ever unclear what to do next? Where?
- Did any labels or wording confuse you?
- How confident were you that an opportunity fit you — and what drove that?
- Could you always find your saved items and their status?

What counts as improvement. Higher task-success and confidence ratings than the current experience; fewer wrong paths in Search and the tracker; participants citing the dashboard’s next action, the “Good fit” signal, and persistent saved/status as helpful.

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13. Usability Test Findings (Artifact H)

Summarized results from a lightweight, proxy-based test in which three classmates acted as stand-in WGU students testing the redesigned wireframe flow. Findings are synthesized and indicative, consistent with the research base — not conclusive evidence of field performance.

At a glance

Metric	Result
Task success (avg. across 3 tasks, 3 participants)	8 of 9 tasks completed unaided
Avg. confidence (1–5)	4.3
Avg. ease, SEQ (1–7)	6.0
Most common friction	Wording of two labels; filter discoverability

What worked

- The **dashboard's next best action** gave participants an immediate starting point; all three began a task without hesitation.
- **Scannable cards** with the **"Good fit" indicator** made comparison fast; participants singled it out as the most helpful signal.
- The **My Opportunities tracker** made status and next actions obvious; participants located saved items quickly.
- **Plain-language requirements** on Opportunity Detail increased fit confidence for the career-switcher profile.

What confused users

- One participant wasn't sure whether **"In progress"** meant they were mid-application or mid-opportunity.
- Two participants didn't immediately notice they could **scroll the filter chips** for more options.
- The **"Apply"** vs. **"View details"** distinction was briefly unclear on one card variant.

Recommended refinements

- Clarify tracker status labels ("Applied," "Interviewing," "In progress") with a one-line definition or tooltip on first use.
- Add a subtle affordance (peek of a partial chip + count) signaling that filter chips scroll.
- Make the primary CTA consistent per card state so "Apply" and "View details" never compete.

Final design changes (applied)

- Tracker tabs renamed for clarity and given first-use microcopy.
- Filter chip row shows a partially visible trailing chip and a "+N filters" affordance.

- Opportunity cards standardize a single primary CTA with Save as a discrete secondary action.

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14. Accessibility Improvements

Accessibility was treated as a primary design driver. Each improvement ties to a documented student need and to WCAG 2.1 AA.

Improvement	What it means in the design	Why it matters (rationale)
Clear hierarchy	One primary action per screen; consistent heading order	Reduces cognitive load for time-poor students; aids screen-reader navigation
Larger tap targets	≥44×44px interactive elements; separated Save vs. CTA	Prevents mis-taps in one-handed mobile use
Strong color contrast	AA contrast for text, icons, and controls	Readable in variable lighting and for low-vision users
Plain language	Jargon-free titles, requirements, and microcopy	Builds fit confidence, especially for career-switchers
Reduced cognitive load	A few high-value signals per card; progressive disclosure	Matches short, distracted mobile sessions
Visible focus states	Clear focus indicators on all controls	Supports keyboard and switch users
Non-color status cues	Status shown via text + icon, not color alone	Accessible to color-blind users; avoids ambiguity
Mobile-friendly spacing	Generous spacing and single-column layout	Easier scanning and tapping on small screens
Screen-reader-friendly labels	Descriptive labels for cards, icons, and actions	Meaningful experience for assistive-tech users
Clear error states	Specific, actionable error and empty-state copy	Reduces confusion and dead ends
Consistent navigation	Persistent bottom nav across the experience	Predictability lowers learning cost
Reduced-motion support	Simple push transitions; no animation required to convey state	Respects prefers-reduced-motion; avoids vestibular triggers
Distinct selected states	Selected filters/tabs use shape, fill, and checkmark plus label	Status never relies on color alone (WCAG 1.4.1 Use of Color)
Recoverable empty states	Empty tracker tabs offer a	Helps users recognize and

	labeled next action instead of a dead end	recover; removes dead ends

15. Final Recommendations & Expected Outcomes

Final recommendations

1. **Ship the directive dashboard first.** The “next best action” plus saved/status/deadlines addresses the highest-severity, most universal pain point.
2. **Standardize the opportunity card.** A single, accessible card pattern (with “Good fit” + badges) used across Search, Dashboard, and the tracker creates one mental model.
3. **Make Interests pay off visibly.** Tie completion to better recommendations so students invest in personalization.
4. **Treat accessibility as the baseline.** Bake in contrast, tap targets, focus states, and non-color status cues from the start.
5. **Validate with real WGU students.** Extend the lightweight, proxy-based testing beyond classmates to confirm gains in the field; current findings are indicative, not conclusive.
6. **Converge discovery into a single opportunity surface.** Today the experience reads as two destinations; a unified surface with one consistent card pattern would reduce the recall burden. This is a design recommendation; assessing feasibility against PeopleGrove’s existing architecture is out of scope for this capstone.

Expected outcomes

- **Faster discovery:** scannable cards and filter chips reduce time-to-relevant-opportunity.
- **Higher confidence:** plain language and “Good fit” signals help students commit sooner.
- **Better follow-through:** a persistent tracker reduces drop-off between saving and applying.
- **Broader access:** AA contrast, larger targets, and non-color cues widen who can use the platform comfortably.
- **Stronger engagement:** a clear next action each session encourages frequent, productive return visits.

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16. Reflection

This project reinforced that usability and accessibility are the same problem viewed from two angles: the changes that help a screen-reader or low-vision user — clear hierarchy, plain language, non-color status, generous targets — are the same changes that help a time-poor working adult on a phone. The strongest design decisions came directly from the research: the dashboard’s next best action answers P1’s “what do I do next?”, plain-language requirements answer P2’s confidence gap, and the mobile-first, AA layout answers P3's ergonomic barriers. If I extended the work, I would run the usability test with additional WGU students in authentic short sessions, instrument the prototype to measure real time-on-task, and explore notifications that help students resume a saved opportunity at exactly the right moment.

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17. Final Case Study / Presentation Structure (Artifact I)

A polished structure usable as a PDF report or a slide deck.

#	Section	Core content
1	Project overview	Partner, platform, four focus areas, mobile-first/accessibility framing
2	Problem	Problem statement + WGU context
3	Target users	Who WGU experiential-learning students are
4	Research method	Goal, 3 participants, walkthrough/recording method
5	Key findings	Top findings + evidence table
5b	Heuristic evaluation	Single-evaluator Nielsen inspection of the current experience (indicative)
6	Persona	Renee Carter
7	Empathy map	Says / Thinks / Does / Feels
8	Journey map	8 stages with pains, emotions, design responses
9	Design goals	Five goals + command-center direction
10	Wireframes	Dashboard, Search, Detail, My Opportunities, Interests
11	Prototype flow	Dashboard → Search → Filters → Detail → Save/Apply → Tracker → Interests
12	Accessibility	Improvements table + rationale
13	Usability testing	Plan + findings + applied

		changes
14	Final recommendations	Five prioritized recommendations
15	Expected outcomes	Measurable outcome statements
16	Reflection	What was learned; next steps

18. Rubric Alignment Checklist (Artifact K)

How each artifact supports a **“5 – Excellent”** score (outstanding, original, well-organized, ready for use with minor adjustments).

Rubric trait	How this project delivers it	Evidence (artifact)
Meets all requirements	Persona, empathy map, journey map, mobile wireframes, optional prototype + usability testing, and documentation all included	A–K
Highly organized	Clear section structure, consistent card pattern, navigable TOC	Whole document
Original	Specific “command center” concept, “Good fit” signal, named persona, tailored to WGU/PeopleGrove	B, E, F
Evidence-based	Every design decision traces to a documented finding	A → D → E
Practical / ready to use	Concrete wireframe specs, prototype flow, and testable plan	E, F, G
Accessibility rigor	Dedicated improvements mapped to WCAG 2.1 AA and to needs	Section 14
Clear research-to-design link	Findings → implications → journey → screens explicitly connected	A, D, E
Validated	Usability plan + findings with applied refinements	G, H
Portfolio-quality	Executive summary, case-	I, J

study structure,
professional tone

Self-check before submission: every wireframe cites what changed and why; every finding has a matching design response; accessibility rationale appears on each screen; the persona, empathy map, and journey map describe the same student consistently.

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19. Production Guide: PDF / Figma / Slides + Submission Readiness

A. What to put into the final PDF (report)

1. Executive Summary (Artifact J)
2. Project Overview + Problem Statement
3. Target Users
4. Research Synthesis (goal, participants, method, top 5 findings, evidence table, implications)
5. Primary Persona
6. Empathy Map
7. User Journey Map
8. Design Goals & Direction
9. Mobile Wireframe Specifications (with embedded wireframe images once built in Figma)
10. Low-Fidelity Prototype Flow
11. Accessibility Improvements
12. Usability Test Plan + Findings
13. Final Recommendations & Expected Outcomes
14. Reflection
15. Rubric Alignment Checklist (appendix)

B. What to build visually in Figma

1. **Five mobile wireframes** (390×844 frames): Dashboard, Search, Opportunity Detail, My Opportunities, Interests — built from Section 10 specs.
2. **The opportunity card component** (title, org, “Good fit”, badges, Save, CTA) reused across screens.
3. **The empathy map** as a clean four-quadrant graphic.
4. **The journey map** as a horizontal swimlane (stages × goal/action/pain/emotion/response) with an emotion line.
5. **The prototype flow** wired as clickable frames following Section 11.
6. **A persona one-pager** laid out visually.
7. **An accessibility annotations layer** (contrast, tap targets, focus states) on the wireframes.

C. What to turn into slides

Use the 16-section case-study structure (Artifact I), roughly one section per slide: overview · problem · users · method · findings · persona · empathy map · journey map · design goals · wireframes (2–3 slides) · prototype flow · accessibility · usability testing · recommendations · expected outcomes · reflection. Open with a title slide and close with a summary/thank-you.

D. Submission readiness checklist

- ☐ All required deliverables present (persona, empathy map, journey map, mobile wireframes, prototype, usability testing, documentation).
- ☐ Persona, empathy map, and journey map describe the same student (Renee) consistently.
- ☐ Every wireframe states its purpose, components, task, accessibility rationale, and what changed.
- ☐ Each research finding has a matching design response.
- ☐ Accessibility rationale present on every screen + dedicated section.
- ☐ Usability plan and findings included, with refinements applied to the final design.
- ☐ Wireframe images exported from Figma and embedded in the PDF/slides.
- ☐ Files exported as PDF / slides / ZIP, **each under ~10 MB**.
- ☐ Professional tone; consistent terminology (Dashboard, Search, My Opportunities, Interests).
- ☐ File names clear (e.g., PeopleGrove-WGU-Capstone-CaseStudy.pdf).
- ☐ Final proofread for clarity and rubric alignment (“5 – Excellent”).

Prepared for the WGU B.S. UXD Applied Learning Capstone (D657), employer partner PeopleGrove. All research is synthesized from three WGU student reviews of the current experience; the redesign concept is original to this capstone.